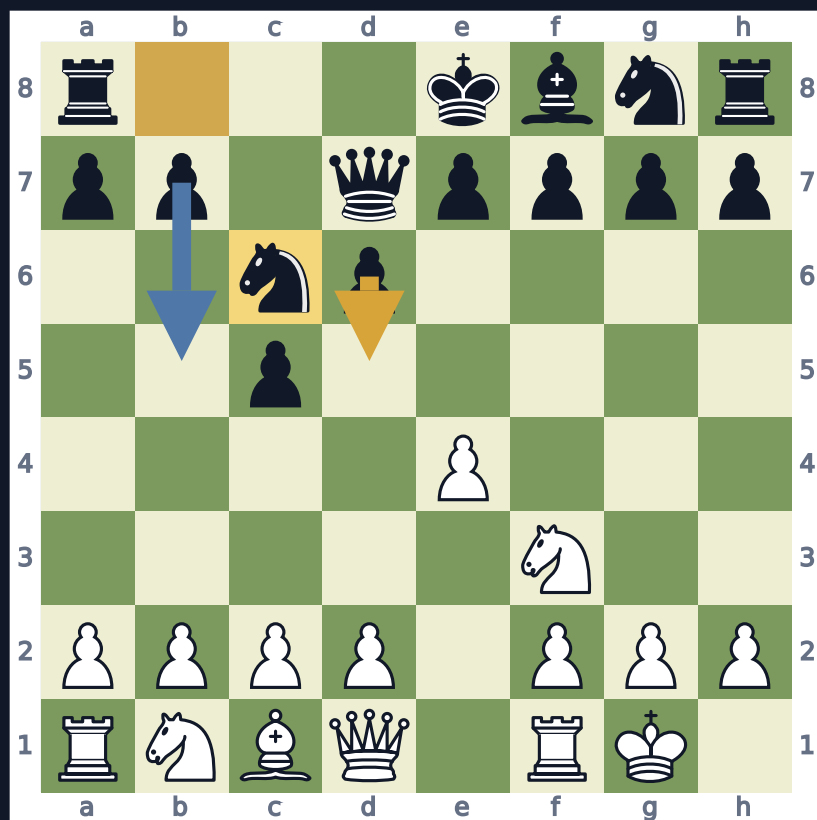


12

Moscow and Rossolimo Systems

Bishop checks, structural choices, and how Black avoids a passive doubled-pawn middlegame.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will treat Bb5 systems as strategic decisions about structure and bishop value, not as harmless sidelines.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 067 | PAGE 4

Decode: Moscow with 3...Bd7*Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.*

LESSON 068 | PAGE 8

Play: Moscow with 3...Bd7*Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.*

LESSON 069 | PAGE 12

Decode: Moscow with 3...Nc6*A bishop check often asks for a development choice, not a bishop hunt.*

LESSON 070 | PAGE 16

Play: Moscow with 3...Nc6*A bishop check often asks for a development choice, not a bishop hunt.*

LESSON 071 | PAGE 20

Decode: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns*Doubled pawns are weaknesses only when their dynamic compensation is unused.*

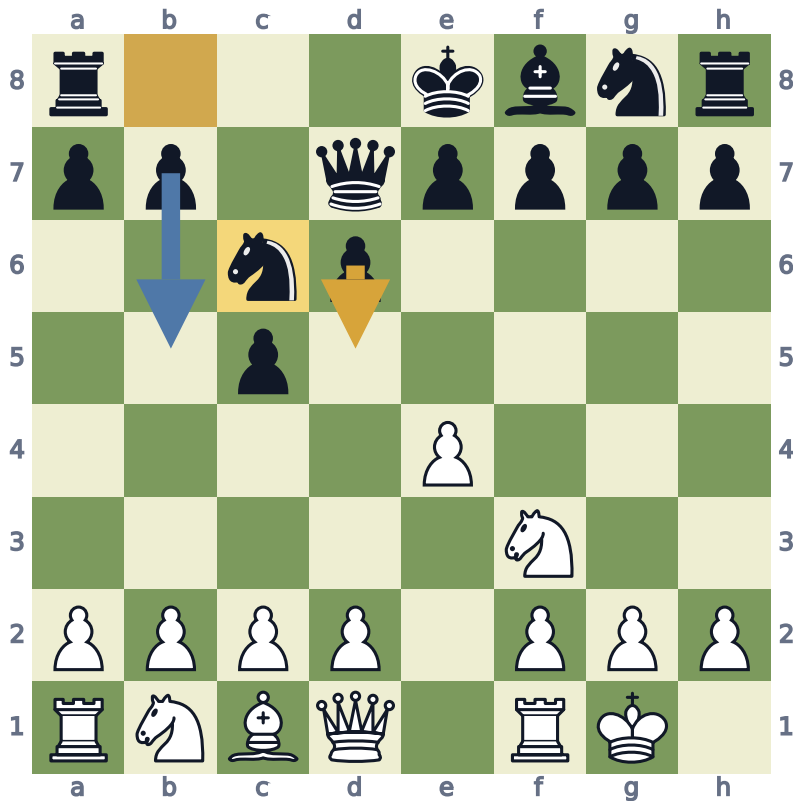
LESSON 072 | PAGE 24

Play: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns*Doubled pawns are weaknesses only when their dynamic compensation is unused.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will treat Bb5 systems as strategic decisions about structure and bishop value, not as harmless sidelines.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Moscow with 3...Bd7



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...Bd7 offers a bishop trade and keeps the pawn structure intact, accepting that the queen may recapture and lose a tempo later.

DECISION RULE

After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Develop smoothly, prepare ...Bg7, and use ...d5 when White's modest center permits it.

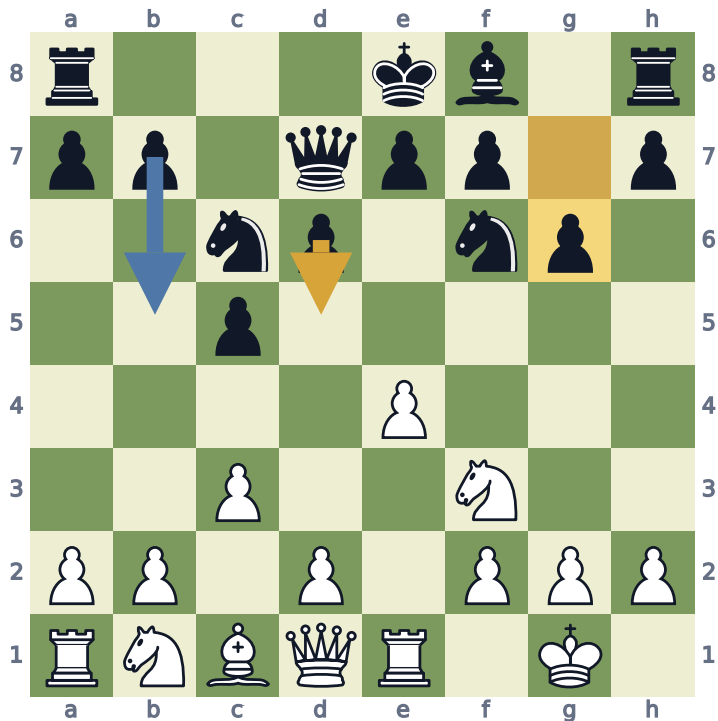
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses c3-d4 and Re1 to gain central time against the queen and black king.

MEMORY RULE | Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...Bd7 offers a bishop trade and keeps the pawn structure intact, accepting that the queen may recapture and lose a tempo later.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Develop smoothly, prepare ...Bg7, and use ...d5 when White's modest center permits it.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses c3-d4 and Re1 to gain central time against the queen and black king.

FAILURE MODE

Treating the bishop exchange as automatic equality while White builds a free center.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

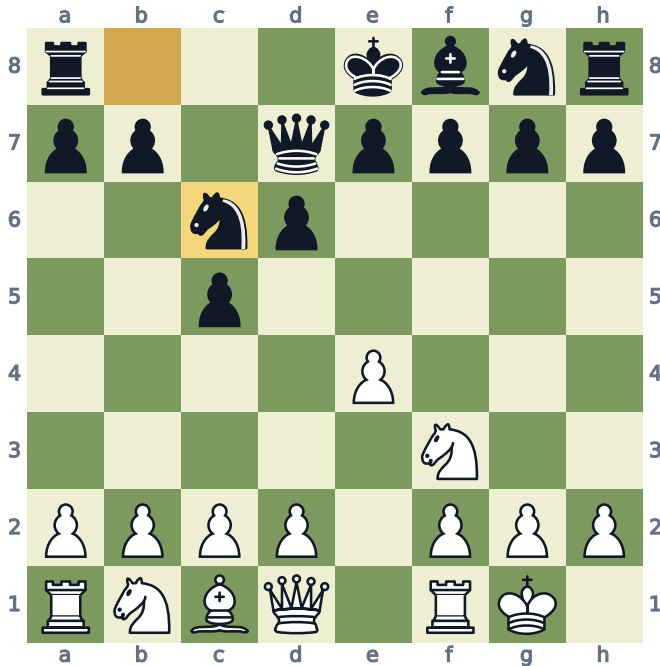
RULE | Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bb5+ Bd7 4. Bxd7+ Qxd7 5. O-O Nc6 6. c3 Nf6 7. Re1 g6



- Bb5+: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bd7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bxd7+: White releases tension by capturing on d7; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Qxd7: Black releases tension by capturing on d7; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...Bd7 offers a bishop trade and keeps the pawn structure intact, accepting that the queen may recapture and lose a tempo later.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi? White's resistance is: White uses c3-d4 and Re1 to gain central time against the queen and black king. The line fails as a template when: Treating the bishop exchange as automatic equality while White builds a free center.

STORE THIS | Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

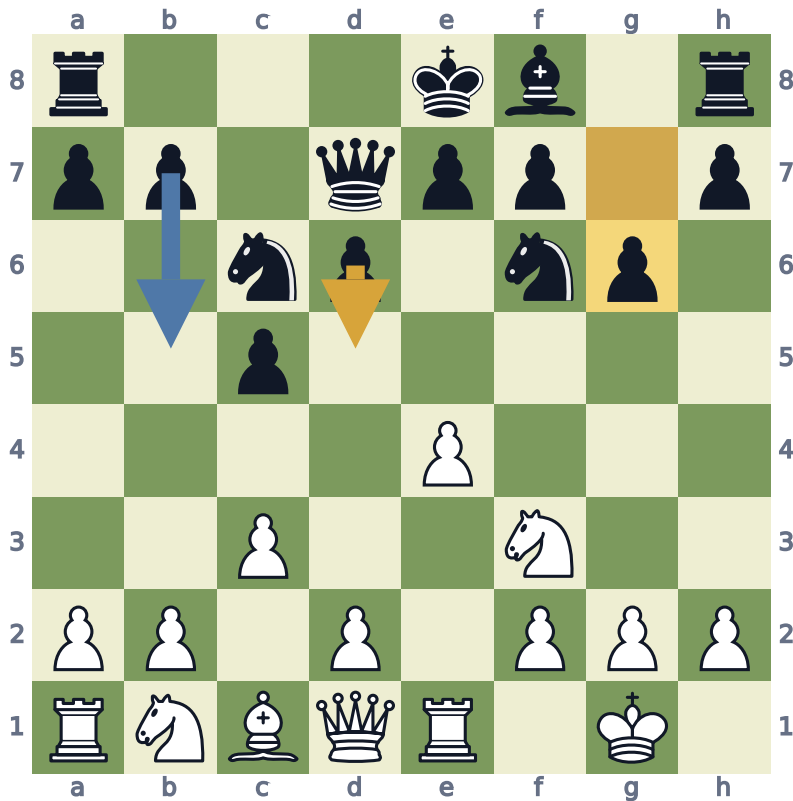
1. ...Bd7 offers a bishop trade and keeps the pawn structure intact, accepting that the queen may recapture and lose a tempo later. 2. Develop smoothly, prepare ...Bg7, and use ...d5 when White's modest center permits it. 3. White uses c3-d4 and Re1 to gain central time against the queen and black king. 4. After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi? 5. Treating the bishop exchange as automatic equality while White builds a free center.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Bb5+ Bd7 4. Bxd7+ Qxd7 5. O-O Nc6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Moscow with 3...Bd7



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...Bd7 offers a bishop trade and keeps the pawn structure intact, accepting that the queen may recapture and lose a tempo later.

DECISION RULE

After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Develop smoothly, prepare ...Bg7, and use ...d5 when White's modest center permits it.

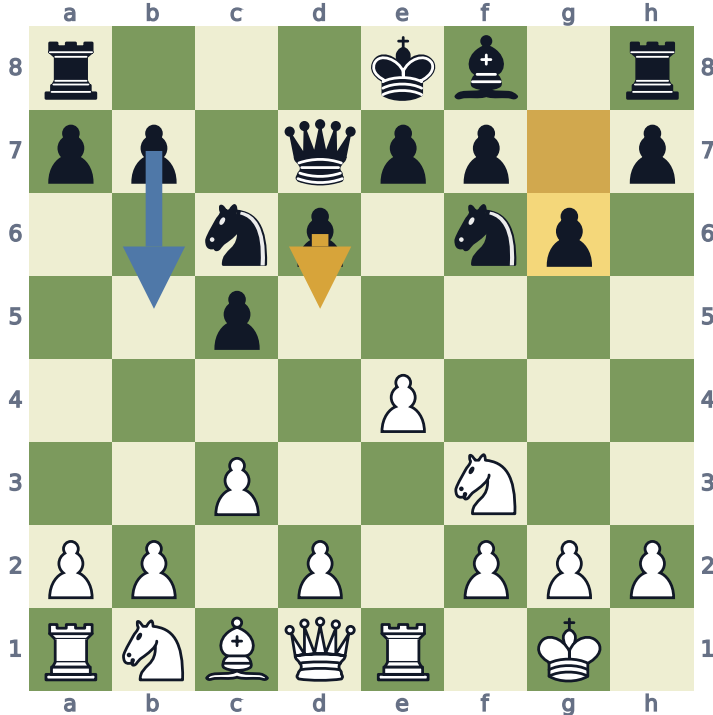
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses c3-d4 and Re1 to gain central time against the queen and black king.

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

Develop smoothly, prepare ...Bg7, and use ...d5 when White's modest center permits it.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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FAILURE MODE

Treating the bishop exchange as automatic equality while White builds a free center.

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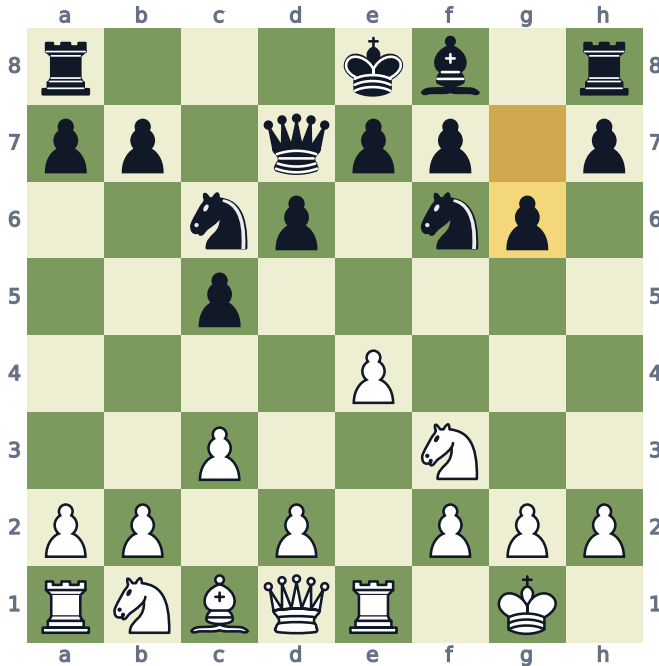
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Move-by-move meaning

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- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- c3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...Bd7 offers a bishop trade and keeps the pawn structure intact, accepting that the queen may recapture and lose a tempo later.

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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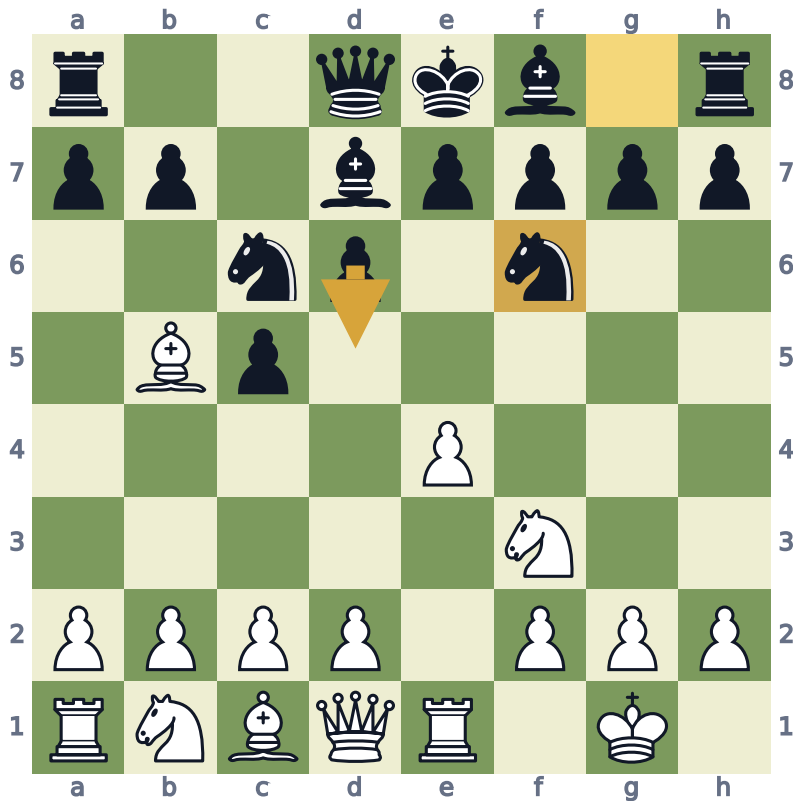
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. O-O Nc6 6. c3 Nf6 7. Re1 g6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Moscow with 3...Nc6



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Blocking with the knight preserves more pieces and invites a strategic game where White may retreat rather than exchange.

DECISION RULE

Should Black challenge the bishop now, or is central development more urgent?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Develop, question the bishop, and prepare ...Bg7 without allowing e5 to gain decisive time.

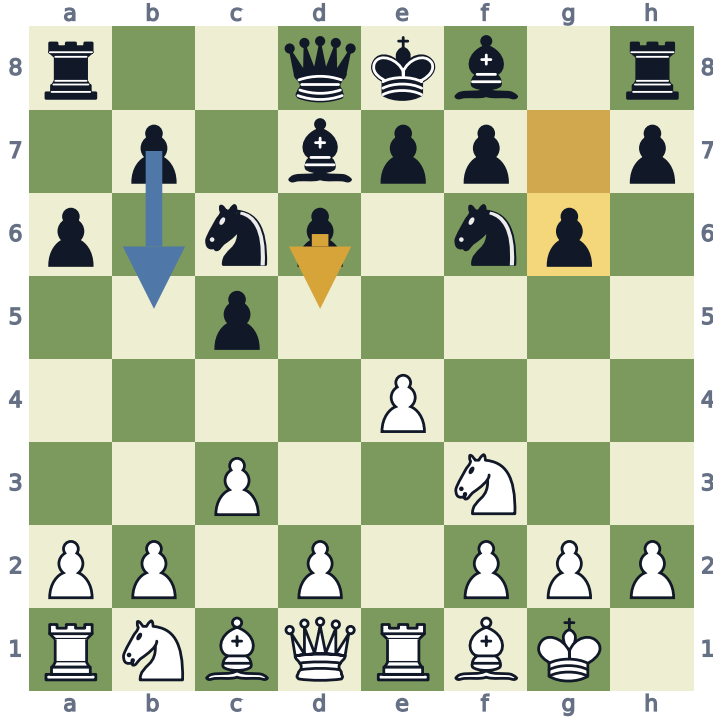
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White preserves the bishop, builds c3-d4, and uses the pin or retreat to gain a favorable center.

MEMORY RULE | A bishop check often asks for a development choice, not a bishop hunt.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Blocking with the knight preserves more pieces and invites a strategic game where White may retreat rather than exchange.

BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White preserves the bishop, builds c3-d4, and uses the pin or retreat to gain a favorable center.

FAILURE MODE

Chasing the bishop with pawns while White occupies the center with tempo.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Should Black challenge the bishop now, or is central development more urgent? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

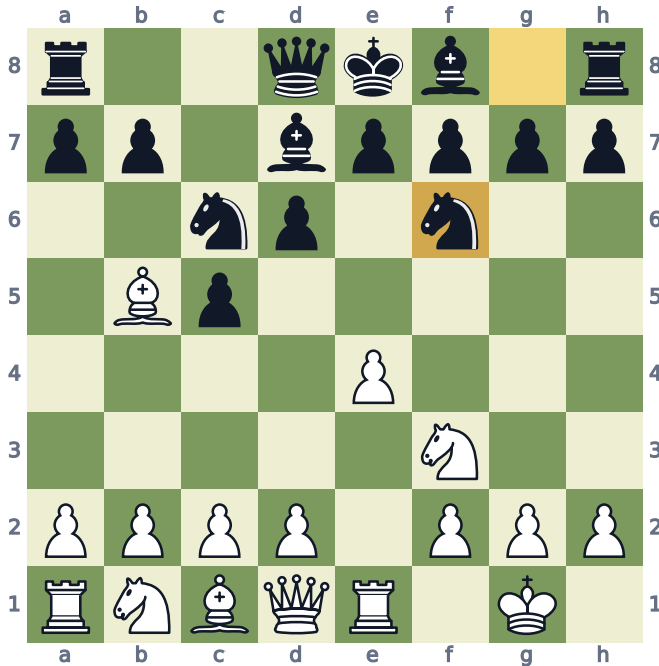
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Move-by-move meaning

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1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bb5+ Nc6 4. O-O Bd7 5. Re1 Nf6 6. c3 a6 7. Bf1 g6



- Bb5+: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
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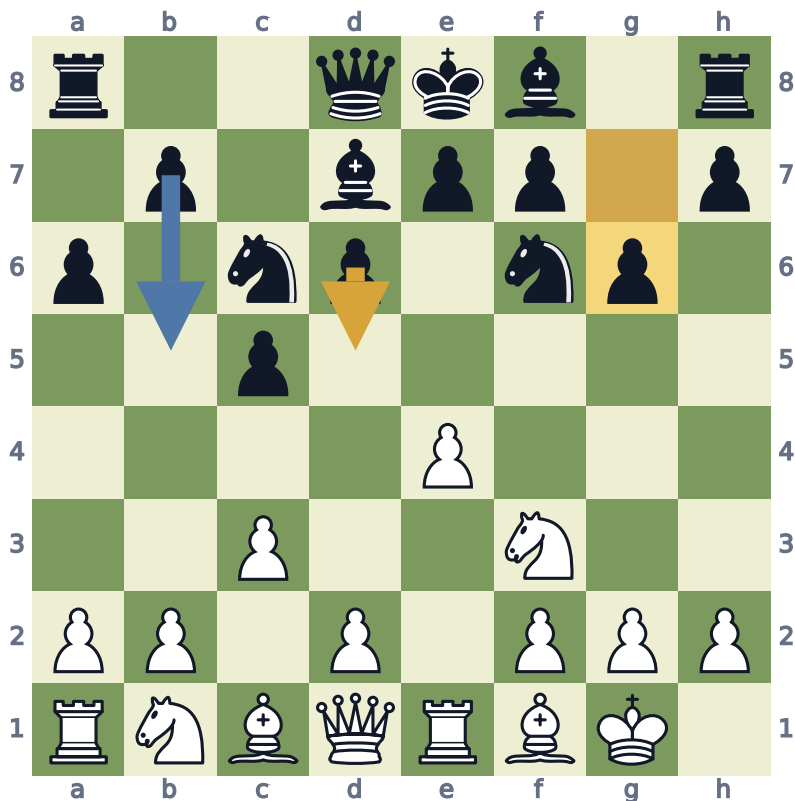
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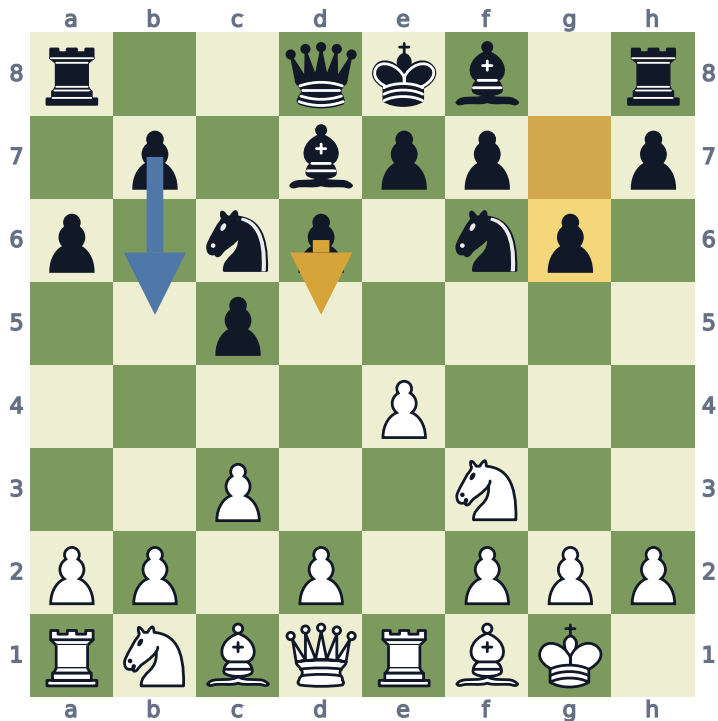
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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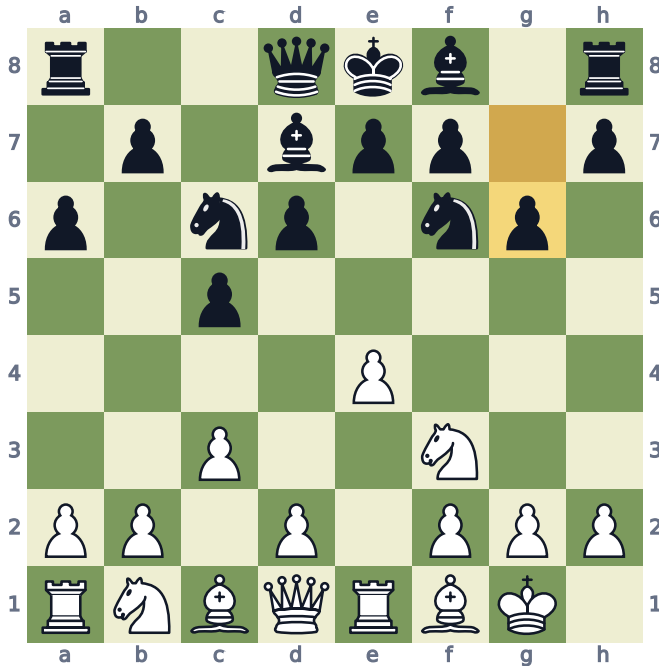
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- c3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bf1: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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ANSWER KEY

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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Re1 Nf6 6. c3 a6 7. Bf1 g6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Bxc6 gives Black doubled c-pawns but also the bishop pair, central control, and an open b-file; the structure is unbalanced, not simply damaged.

DECISION RULE

Which asset compensates the doubled pawns, and how can it become active before an endgame fixes the weaknesses?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Use the bishop pair, prepare ...e5 or ...f5, and make the c-pawns control important central squares.

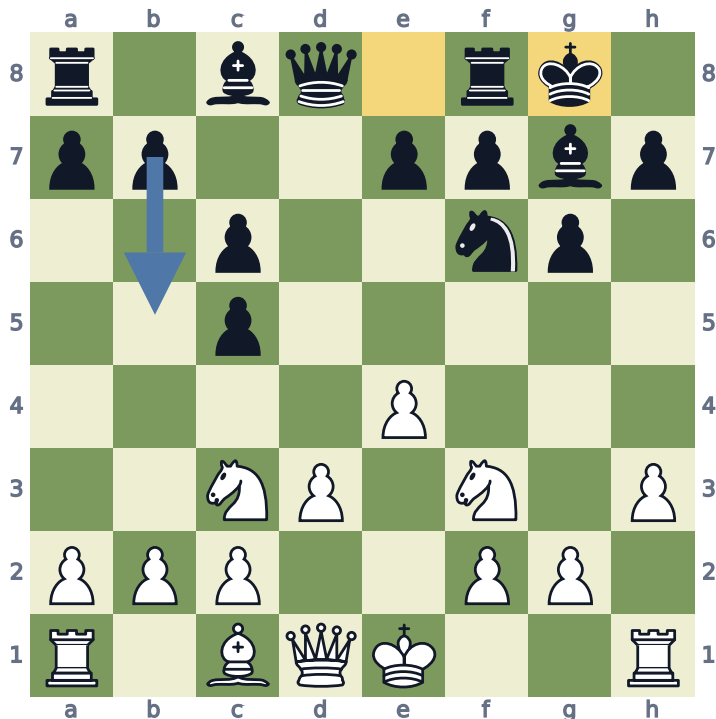
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White targets c5 and c6, uses dark-square control, and seeks a favorable knight-versus-bishop game.

MEMORY RULE | Doubled pawns are weaknesses only when their dynamic compensation is unused.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Bxc6 gives Black doubled c-pawns but also the bishop pair, central control, and an open b-file; the structure is unbalanced, not simply damaged.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Use the bishop pair, prepare ...e5 or ...f5, and make the c-pawns control important central squares.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White targets c5 and c6, uses dark-square control, and seeks a favorable knight-versus-bishop game.

FAILURE MODE

Defending the pawns passively and never using the bishop pair or open files.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which asset compensates the doubled pawns, and how can it become active before an endgame fixes the weaknesses? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 g6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. d3 Bg7 6. h3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O



- Bb5: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- g6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bxc6: White releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- dxc6: Black releases tension by capturing on c6; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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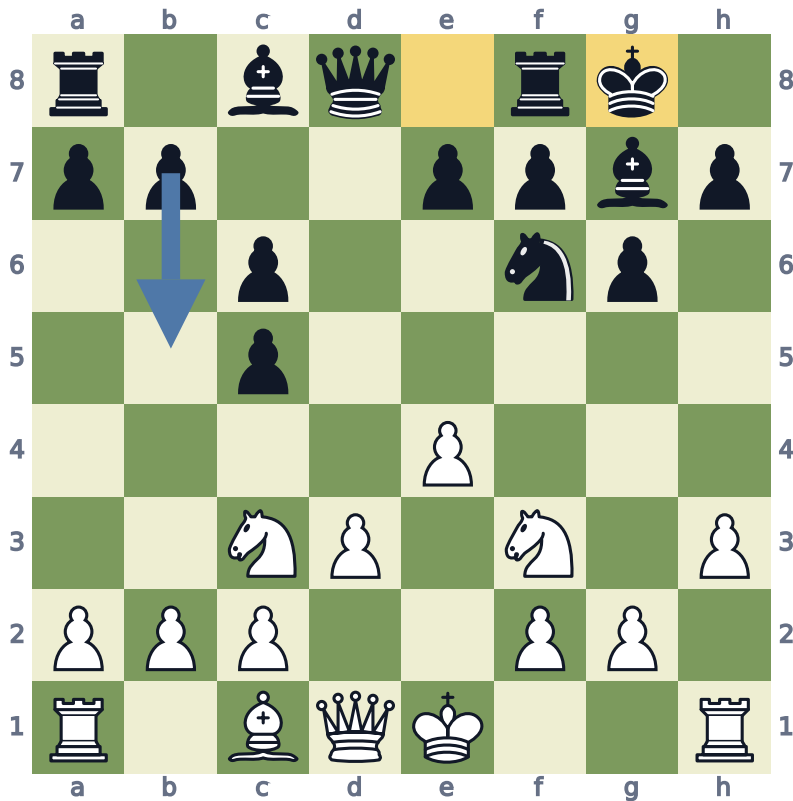
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. Bb5 g6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. d3 Bg7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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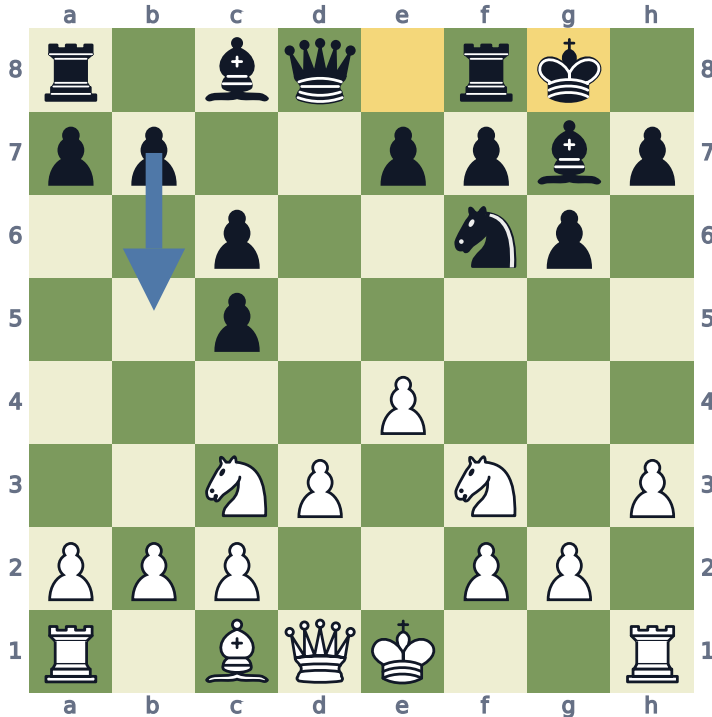
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White targets c5 and c6, uses dark-square control, and seeks a favorable knight-versus-bishop game.

MEMORY RULE | Doubled pawns are weaknesses only when their dynamic compensation is unused.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK AIMS FOR

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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Defending the pawns passively and never using the bishop pair or open files.

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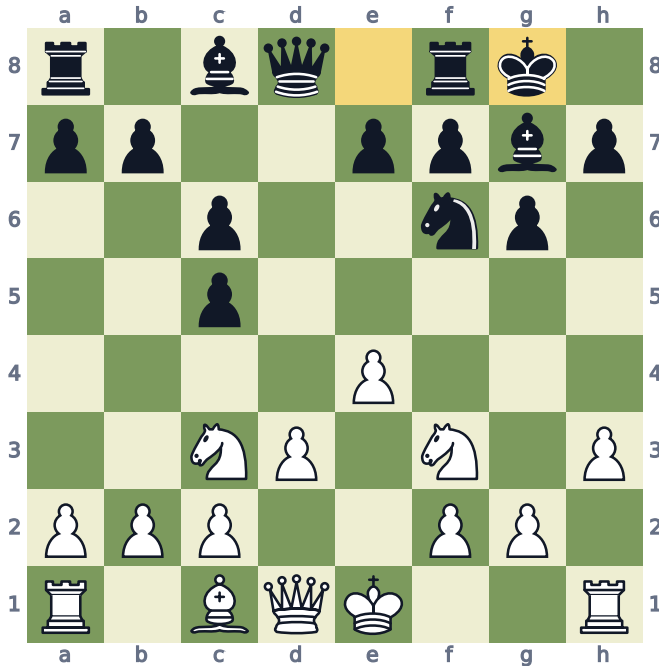
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 g6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. d3 Bg7 6. h3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O



- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Bg7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- h3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Bxc6 gives Black doubled c-pawns but also the bishop pair, central control, and an open b-file; the structure is unbalanced, not simply damaged.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which asset compensates the doubled pawns, and how can it become active before an endgame fixes the weaknesses? White's resistance is: White targets c5 and c6, uses dark-square control, and seeks a favorable knight-versus-bishop game. The line fails as a template when: Defending the pawns passively and never using the bishop pair or open files.

STORE THIS | Doubled pawns are weaknesses only when their dynamic compensation is unused.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Bxc6 gives Black doubled c-pawns but also the bishop pair, central control, and an open b-file; the structure is unbalanced, not simply damaged. 2. Use the bishop pair, prepare ...e5 or ...f5, and make the c-pawns control important central squares. 3. White targets c5 and c6, uses dark-square control, and seeks a favorable knight-versus-bishop game. 4. Which asset compensates the doubled pawns, and how can it become active before an endgame fixes the weaknesses? 5. Defending the pawns passively and never using the bishop pair or open files.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. d3 Bg7 6. h3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 067 Decode: Moscow with 3...Bd7

Prompt: After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi?

Recall: Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.

LESSON 068 Play: Moscow with 3...Bd7

Prompt: After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi?

Recall: Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.

LESSON 069 Decode: Moscow with 3...Nc6

Prompt: Should Black challenge the bishop now, or is central development more urgent?

Recall: A bishop check often asks for a development choice, not a bishop hunt.

LESSON 070 Play: Moscow with 3...Nc6

Prompt: Should Black challenge the bishop now, or is central development more urgent?

Recall: A bishop check often asks for a development choice, not a bishop hunt.

LESSON 071 Decode: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns

Prompt: Which asset compensates the doubled pawns, and how can it become active before an endgame fixes the weaknesses?

Recall: Doubled pawns are weaknesses only when their dynamic compensation is unused.

LESSON 072 Play: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns

Prompt: Which asset compensates the doubled pawns, and how can it become active before an endgame fixes the weaknesses?

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Moscow with 3...Bd7

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bb5+ Bd7 4. Bxd7+ Qxd7 5. O-O Nc6 6. c3 Nf6 7. Re1 g6

Decision: After the exchange on d7, does the queen have a useful role or become a target to central tempi?

Memory: Keeping the structure is useful only if the queen's recapture does not cost coordination.

CARD 2

Moscow with 3...Nc6

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bb5+ Nc6 4. O-O Bd7 5. Re1 Nf6 6. c3 a6 7. Bf1 g6

Decision: Should Black challenge the bishop now, or is central development more urgent?

Memory: A bishop check often asks for a development choice, not a bishop hunt.

CARD 3

Rossolimo doubled c-pawns

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 g6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. d3 Bg7 6. h3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

Decision: Which asset compensates the doubled pawns, and how can it become active before an endgame fixes the weaknesses?

Memory: Doubled pawns are weaknesses only when their dynamic compensation is unused.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
067 Decode: Moscow with 3...Bd7	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
068 Play: Moscow with 3...Bd7	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
069 Decode: Moscow with 3...Nc6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
070 Play: Moscow with 3...Nc6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
071 Decode: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
072 Play: Rossolimo doubled c-pawns	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.